FOOD SECURITY IN THE GLOBAL SOUTH

CONFRONTING ENVIRONMENTAL, ECONOMIC, AND GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES

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The current situation

Food security is a situation where everyone always has access to sufficient, safe, and healthy food that is suitable for their dietary requirements. The United Nations (UN), through its Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 2 'Zero Hunger', predicts achieving global food security by 2030. Yet, with the world's population now exceeding 8 billion in 2025, this target proves unrealistic in every form. While the goal is noble, achieving global food security under current macro conditions seems not only improbable but extremely complex.

The Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) projects that 512 million people will still face hunger by 2030, further highlighting the immense challenge of achieving the UN's target of zero hunger. Hunger remains a persistent challenge in the Global South. In 2024, nine of the world's top ten food-insecure countries were found in this region. The scale of the crisis is profound, with more than 340 million people – excluding populations in Asia and Oceania – experiencing hunger during the same period. These figures highlight the deep structural inequalities and vulnerabilities that continue to undermine food security across the Global South, particularly in countries such as Palestine, Sudan, Haiti, and South Sudan, which all made it to the top ten world's hungriest countries in 2024.

Key obstacles to food security in the Global South

Environmental issues

Recurrent droughts, floods, and extreme temperatures have disrupted farming systems, damaged infrastructure, and reduced agricultural yields in the Global South. Many smallholder farmers lack access to irrigation and climate-resilient seeds, leaving them exposed to environmental shocks.

Dependence on rainfed agriculture

Approximately 70% of farmers in Africa, South Asia, and Latin America rely on rainfed agriculture. Limited water supply due to the absence of rain increases the risk of crop failure and undermines food security.

Limited access to inputs and technology

Farmers in the Global South countries, particularly in Africa, face barriers to accessing improved seeds and fertilisers, mechanised tools, and digital technologies due to high costs, limited credit facilities, and weak agricultural extension systems.

Governance and policy inefficiencies

Weak institutions, inconsistent agricultural policies, and corruption reduce investment in food systems in the Global South. Lack of coordinated land reform, poor implementation, and insufficient social protection programmes hinder progress.



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Mushrooming population and urbanisation

Rapid population growth intensifies pressure on land and water resources, while urban expansion converts fertile farmland into non-agricultural uses, increasing dependence on imports.

Conflict and political instability

Civil unrest and conflict displace communities, destroy food supply chains, and limit humanitarian access. In regions like the Sahel, Sudan, Palestine, Haiti, and South Sudan, insecurity is a key driver of hunger.

The way forward

To promote climate-resilient agriculture, countries should prioritise investments in irrigation infrastructure, water harvesting technologies, and effective early-warning systems to help farmers adapt to changing weather patterns.

Equally important is the widespread adoption of drought-tolerant farming systems that can sustain productivity under extreme conditions. Empowering women farmers is another crucial pillar of sustainable agricultural development. This includes securing their land rights, ensuring equitable access to financing and agricultural training, and embedding gender equality across all agricultural policy frameworks.

Finally, strengthening governance structures and relevant policies is essential to achieving long-term food security. Governments must develop coherent agricultural and food security strategies while improving coordination between public and private sector stakeholders to ensure more efficient, inclusive, and resilient agricultural systems.

The Global South faces a complex network of obstacles to food security. The problem is not just food availability but access, stability, and utilisation – issues deeply rooted in economic, environmental, and governance structures. Achieving sustainable food systems requires inclusive and forward-looking strategies that combine climate adaptation, gender empowerment, and improved governance and policies.